Fintech Bootcamp

Self Paced Information

Group 2

This presentation covers 9 topics explored during the Fintech Bootcamp self-paced sessions.
Each topic reflects our group's learning journey — from AI in banking to the broader fintech landscape.

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2. Building a Bank from Scratch
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Topic 01

AI in Banking

Group Reflection

AI is no longer just a tool in the background — it is actively reshaping how banks operate and interact with customers. This topic explores how our understanding of AI in banking evolved: from simple automation to enterprise transformation, governance, and the future of work.

Topic 01: AI in Banking

1. AI as a Core Driver of Bank Transformation

Our key insight: AI is integral to redesigning workflows and decision-making — not just a side experiment.

From isolated tools to integrated model

Banks benefit far more when AI is connected to data flows, policies, and business goals. Treating AI as a core part of operations creates greater value than isolated use cases.

Multi-agent systems

Multiple AI tools working together to manage complex workflows — a game-changer. Example: in customer underwriting, AI can collect data, assess risks, and support decision-making — tasks previously done manually, saving time and improving consistency.

Human oversight remains essential

As AI takes on more complex tasks, human judgment shifts from routine decisions to overseeing AI actions and ensuring accountability. Managers' role becomes setting clear boundaries and governance for AI systems.

What we initially overlooked

We had underestimated how AI embedded in a bank's core structure creates exponentially more value. The concept of orchestrating multiple AI agents to handle end-to-end workflows was a major realization for our group.

Topic 01: AI in Banking

2. AI in Financial Services: Practical Applications & Real-World Use Cases

Morgan Stanley & OpenAI

AI helps financial advisors retrieve knowledge faster and serve clients more efficiently. Crucially: AI augments advisors, not replaces them. Advisors spend less time on manual searches and more on client relationships.

Bank of America

Over 90% of employees use AI tools, highlighting the importance of broad adoption. Key lesson: AI investments only deliver returns when tied to real workflows and when there is organisational discipline.

Klarna & the workforce question

Klarna used AI to boost productivity and operate with fewer employees. This raises broader questions about the future of work and the balance between human labour and machine assistance in banking.

Common thread: AI in banking is not about replacing people — it is about augmenting them to do more meaningful work.

Topic 01: AI in Banking

3. The Role of AI in Driving Embedded Finance

A significant realization: agentic commerce — where AI not only suggests actions but executes them within defined policies.

Agentic commerce — the Brex example

AI can automate processes like procurement, payments, and approvals. This is where AI and financial services become fully integrated into the fabric of business operations — not just connected, but embedded.

From transactional banking to systemic financial management

The future of finance appears to be one where banks and fintech companies move from offering standalone services to creating embedded financial ecosystems. AI will orchestrate these systems, ensuring seamless operations that are both efficient and compliant.

This shift from transactional banking to systemic management marked a turning point in how our group views the future of banking.

Topic 01: AI in Banking

4. Governance and Control: The Challenge Ahead

Dual regulatory burden

Fintech companies face both financial regulations AND AI-specific rules. The EU AI Act imposes strict guidelines on AI in finance, especially for high-risk activities like credit scoring and fraud detection. While this can slow innovation, it is necessary to maintain trust and accountability.

KBC's AI stack as a blueprint

KBC combines data infrastructure, APIs, cybersecurity, and model operations into a comprehensive AI framework. The lesson: banks cannot simply adopt AI in isolated areas. They need to integrate AI into core processes with cross-functional collaboration to capture real value.

Key governance principles: transparency, accountability, auditability, and clear human-oversight mechanisms — especially for high-risk AI decisions.

Topic 01: AI in Banking

5. The Future of AI in Banking

AI will continue to evolve from supporting roles to more autonomous functions. The future of banking will be characterised by AI orchestration — AI systems taking on a more active role in managing workflows, optimising decisions, and improving customer experiences.

Stage 1

AI in the Background

Credit scoring, fraud detection, model optimisation — AI supports human decisions invisibly and in real-time.

Stage 2

AI Copilots

AI assists employees with knowledge retrieval, drafting, recommendations and workflow support, while humans remain in control.

Stage 3

Agentic AI

AI orchestrates and executes parts of financial work. This is where the strategic and ethical questions become most important.

Evolution must be carefully managed to ensure human oversight remains central.

Topic 01: AI in Banking

6. Conclusion: Our Main Takeaways

The real value of AI in banking will come from combining AI's analytical power with human judgement. Banks that succeed will foster trust through transparent, accountable AI systems while leveraging AI's capabilities to enhance operational efficiency and customer experience.

- AI is a management and operating-model issue, not just a technology issue
- Multi-agent systems can handle complex workflows that single models cannot
- Human oversight and accountability must remain central as AI grows more autonomous
- Governance (EU AI Act, dual regulatory burden) shapes what banks can and cannot do with AI
- The spectrum: AI in background → AI copilots → Agentic AI is the key mental model

Topic 02

Building a Bank From Scratch

Group Reflection

Based on Tom Blomfield's Y Combinator talk about Monzo, we explored what it truly takes to build a digital bank from scratch — from product design and trust-building to regulation and scaling.

Topic 02: Building a Bank from Scratch

1. What We Learned About Building a Bank from Scratch

Start narrow — the wedge strategy

Monzo began with a simple prepaid card, not a full banking licence. This iterative approach allowed them to learn fast, gather feedback, and prove real demand long before becoming a fully licensed bank.

Solve real customer pain points

Success in fintech doesn't come from being digital alone, but from solving frustrations better than incumbents. Monzo identified poor interfaces, lack of spending visibility, and slow support — and built around transparency, speed, and customer-centric design.

Trust migration is key

Monzo didn't expect customers to trust them with everything from the start. Instead, they encouraged users to start small and gradually move more of their financial lives onto the platform. Trust must be earned step by step.

Beyond technology

Building a bank is a product challenge, a trust challenge, a regulatory challenge, and a scaling challenge — not just a tech project. Monzo's story reinforced that fintech disruption is fundamentally human.

Key shift in thinking: we initially thought building a bank required years of complex licensing and massive infrastructure — Monzo showed otherwise.

Topic 02: Building a Bank from Scratch

2. Monzo's Basic Strategy

The most eye-opening aspect: how Monzo strategically launched early — even when the product wasn't fully functional.

Launch embarrassingly early

Blomfield emphasised that launching an incomplete product was critical to learning from users. Fintech startups need to fail fast, gather feedback, and make quick improvements — an approach traditional banks would be hesitant to try.

The prepaid card as a bridge product

Before Monzo had a full current account, they offered a prepaid card. This let them test their core hypothesis with real users and slowly evolve toward a full banking licence — without waiting for all regulatory hurdles to be cleared first.

Principle: speed of learning > product perfection at the start.

Topic 02: Building a Bank from Scratch

3. Lessons from Monzo's Story

Start with a real pain point

Don't try to create a perfect product from day one. Focus on solving specific frustrations that customers have with traditional banking.

Use regulation as a process, not an excuse

Monzo treated regulation as something to work through, not a reason to delay. Innovation and compliance can coexist.

Keep core capabilities in-house

Outsourcing too much of the core stack can slow a bank down. Keeping key capabilities like data flow, customer experience, and operating models in-house maintains speed and quality control.

Customer service is part of the product

Monzo saw customer support as a strategic advantage, not a cost centre. High-quality service builds customer loyalty — and loyalty is a competitive weapon in fintech.

Topic 02: Building a Bank from Scratch

4. Growth, Scaling, and Managing Expectations

Balancing agility with banking rigour

Growth is not just about acquiring users — it's about reliability and operational resilience. Once Monzo gained customers, security, compliance, and fraud controls became critical. A challenger bank must balance startup agility with the rigour of banking infrastructure.

The human side of building a bank

Blomfield spoke openly about the anxiety and pressure that founders face. Building a fintech company isn't just about code and licensing — it's about managing uncertainty and continuously making decisions in a high-pressure environment.

What this means for us: building any financial product requires both the boldness of a startup and the discipline of a regulated institution.

Topic 02: Building a Bank from Scratch

5. Why Monzo Became Influential in FinTech

Monzo's influence came from its ability to rethink the banking stack entirely.

Mobile-first, transparency-first, community-first

By focusing on mobile-first experiences, transparency, and community engagement, Monzo proved that a digital bank could succeed without branches or legacy systems. Incumbents are most vulnerable where customer experience is poor and internal systems are rigid.

Disruption alone is not enough

Monzo's journey showed that to sustain growth, a challenger bank needs more than hype. It requires trust, operational resilience, and a viable business model. Being digital and innovative is the entry ticket — not the competitive advantage.

Incumbents are vulnerable where: customer experience is poor · internal systems are rigid · incentives are misaligned with user needs.

Topic 02: Building a Bank from Scratch

6. Conclusion: Our Main Takeaways

Building a bank from scratch is not just about technology — it's about building a product that addresses customer pain points, gaining trust gradually, and creating a scalable operating model.

- Start with a narrow wedge — prove demand before building everything
- Fintech disruption in banking is driven by trust and product quality, not just technology
- Regulation is a process to work through, not a blocker to avoid
- Customer service is a strategic product, not a cost centre
- Startup agility + banking rigour = the challenger bank formula
- Trust migration — encouraging users to move gradually — is the growth engine

Topic 03

Building Financial Infrastructure

Group Reflection

Based on Zach Perret's interview about Plaid, we came to understand that fintech is not just about consumer-facing apps — it's about the invisible infrastructure layer: APIs, data connections, identity tools, and payment rails.

Topic 03: Building Financial Infrastructure

1. What We Learned About Building Financial Infrastructure

The invisible layer is the real value

Real value in modern finance sits in the background: APIs, payment rails, and data systems that connect banks, fintechs, and end users. We had overlooked how crucial these invisible layers are to the functioning of the entire ecosystem.

Plaid's real value: solving a coordination problem

Plaid's success is not about providing a digital bank or a flashy app. Their real value lies in creating an infrastructure layer that allows apps and financial institutions to connect through modern, standardised interfaces — replacing outdated, fragmented legacy processes.

Before this topic, we thought fintech was primarily about consumer-facing apps. Now we understand that the real transformation happens behind the scenes — in the infrastructure that makes everything else possible.

Topic 03: Building Financial Infrastructure

2. The Importance of APIs in Financial Infrastructure

APIs as the backbone of finance

APIs allow companies to connect to other institutions, share data, and automate transactions — without building complex custom solutions from scratch. They reduce friction in onboarding, moving money, verifying identities, and sharing data, while enabling faster innovation.

Modular competition — who controls the stack?

APIs are not just for simple transactions — they are the foundation upon which new financial ecosystems are built. One company may handle the customer interface, another focuses on identity verification, a third on fraud detection. This modular specialisation drives fintech innovation — it's no longer about banks vs. startups, but about who controls the most important layer in the value chain.

What APIs enable:

- Lower costs and faster time-to-market for new products
- Seamless connections between banks, fintechs, payment systems and platforms
- Standardised interfaces that replace fragmented legacy integrations
- Modular ecosystems where each player specialises in one part of the stack

Topic 03: Building Financial Infrastructure

3. Open Banking and Open Finance: The Governance Challenge

Open banking ≠ free access to data

Open banking is about permissioned, secure, and well-governed access. Consumers must have control over where their data goes, while banks and fintechs must ensure data sharing happens responsibly and within clear consent flows.

Open finance is about safe data access

The real winners will not only be those who can move data quickly, but also those who can move it responsibly. Trust and governance are just as important as the underlying technology.

Opportunity for banks — not just compliance

Banks should see open banking as an opportunity, not just a compliance burden. When banks connect well to the market, they can stay relevant even when the customer-facing experience is managed by other brands. This creates a distribution opportunity.

Key question: who is connected to whom, and how can access be revoked when necessary?

Topic 03: Building Financial Infrastructure

4. The Role of Payments and Payment Rails

Payment rails transform how money moves

Payment experience isn't just about how apps look — it's about the underlying infrastructure that supports fast, reliable, and secure transactions. Real-time payment systems like FedNow and RTP enable faster settlements, improved cash-flow visibility, and lower transaction costs.

New rails need adoption, integration, and security

Having new payment rails is not enough. They need to be adopted by institutions, integrated into products, and secured properly to create real value for both businesses and consumers.

If the payment system is slow or unreliable, customers feel it immediately. The infrastructure is not invisible to users — it is the experience.

Topic 03: Building Financial Infrastructure

5. Trust, Security, and Regulation as Part of the Product

Trust is a core product feature

In financial infrastructure, privacy, data protection, compliance, and fraud prevention are not 'add-ons' — they are integral to the product offering. Without these foundational elements, the product experience would collapse.

Infrastructure providers must be trustworthy, not just functional

Companies providing infrastructure don't just need to focus on the technology. They must ensure reliability, security, and trustworthiness to maintain long-term value and avoid being replaced by newer players.

Major takeaway: the companies that provide infrastructure don't just need great technology — they need to be trustworthy partners for the entire ecosystem.

Topic 03: Building Financial Infrastructure

6. What Incumbents Can Learn from This

Banks don't need to dominate the entire customer journey

Traditional banks can capture significant value by becoming key participants in financial infrastructure — offering strong APIs, reliable services, and maintaining trust in data flows — even as fintechs challenge the front-end experiences.

Fintechs need deeper moats over time

A nice user interface is not enough for long-term success. Fintechs need to build deeper moats around their products — whether through data ownership, workflow control, or unique regulatory capabilities. Controlling parts of the infrastructure is often what makes a fintech sustainable.

Conclusion

Financial infrastructure is the foundation of modern finance. The future of fintech lies in creating connected, modular systems that allow institutions and startups to specialise in different parts of the financial stack. The real challenge is not just building these systems but ensuring they are secure, reliable, and trustworthy — only then will the financial ecosystem function effectively at scale.

Topic 03: Building Financial Infrastructure

7. Conclusion: Building Modern Financial Infrastructure

The key takeaway: the future of fintech lies in creating connected, modular systems that allow institutions and startups to specialise in different parts of the financial stack — securely and reliably.

- The invisible infrastructure layer (APIs, rails, data) is where the real value of fintech sits
- APIs reduce friction, lower costs, and enable modular competition across the financial stack
- Open banking requires governance and consent mechanisms — not just open access
- Payment rails must be adopted, integrated, and secured to deliver real value
- Trust, security, and compliance are core product features — not add-ons
- Both incumbents and fintechs must build moats: APIs, data, workflow ownership, or regulatory capability

Topic 04

Blockchain & Crypto

Group Reflection

We moved from viewing crypto as purely speculative to understanding how blockchain technologies — especially stablecoins and tokenisation — are fundamentally changing financial infrastructure through programmability, efficiency, and new forms of value transfer.

Topic 04: Blockchain & Crypto

1. What We Learned About Blockchain and Crypto

From speculation to infrastructure

We initially thought of crypto mainly as an investment vehicle. However, exploring stablecoins — digital tokens pegged to a stable asset like the US dollar — revealed a broader role in payments and financial infrastructure.

Stablecoins are transforming cross-border payments

Stablecoins provide faster, cheaper, and more transparent ways to move value across borders — with 24/7 operations and programmable money that embeds rules and conditions directly into the transaction flow. They are growing fast enough that banks and payment companies cannot afford to ignore them.

Major mindset shift: stablecoins are not niche crypto products — they are becoming serious payments and treasury tools with real advantages over legacy payment rails like SWIFT.

Topic 04: Blockchain & Crypto

2. Why Stablecoins Matter Now

Settlement speed and global coverage

Stablecoins in tokenised cash form improve settlement speed, provide global coverage, and ensure payments are always available. They offer significant advantages over SWIFT, which is often slow and costly.

Programmability — the key differentiator

The ability to embed smart contract functionality into stablecoin transactions adds a layer of flexibility and control that traditional financial systems lack. Money can carry conditions, rules, and logic — not just value.

Changing user expectations

The adoption of stablecoins marks a shift in what users expect from financial systems. Faster and cheaper alternatives — especially for cross-border payments — are changing the benchmark for what 'good' payments feel like. Traditional banking systems are no longer seen as irreplaceable.

Stablecoins represent a shift from: slow rails → fast settlement · opaque pricing → transparent costs · batch processing → real-time 24/7 availability.

Topic 04: Blockchain & Crypto

3. Small Business Use Cases: From Investment to Practical Utility

SMEs — the most impacted users

For small and medium-sized enterprises, stablecoins offer tangible benefits: lower payment costs, faster settlements, and simplified cross-border transfers. Small businesses don't need to believe in crypto ideology — they simply need better financial plumbing.

Stablecoins in volatile currency environments

In countries with volatile currencies, stablecoins serve a dual role: as a payment tool AND as a store of value. This makes them part of a larger financial ecosystem that benefits both developed and emerging markets.

Shift in perspective: from crypto as investment → crypto as operational infrastructure for everyday business payments.

Topic 04: Blockchain & Crypto

4. The Role of Asia in Stablecoin Adoption

Asia leads stablecoin adoption

Asia is currently one of the most active regions for stablecoin use. Key drivers include high levels of cross-border trade, fragmented payment systems, strong digital adoption, and high demand for faster, cheaper dollar transfers.

Adoption is not uniform — it varies by region and use case

In some regions, stablecoin adoption is driven by trade efficiency. In others, it's about remittances, merchant settlement, or access to dollar-backed instruments for monetary stability. The drivers vary significantly, adding complexity to understanding global stablecoin dynamics.

Key insight: stablecoin adoption must be understood regionally, not globally — the same technology solves different problems in different markets.

Topic 04: Blockchain & Crypto

5. Tokenisation: The Bigger Strategic Picture

Tokenising financial assets

Tokenisation allows financial assets — real estate, bonds, loans — to be digitised and moved on blockchain rails. This makes ownership and transfer more efficient, more standardised, and potentially more liquid.

Impact on illiquid assets

Tokenisation allows assets to be divided into smaller portions, making them easier to trade and finance. This could be revolutionary for illiquid assets — increasing liquidity, reducing back-office costs, and making asset transfers far more efficient.

Not just crypto trading — real-world problem solving

Our most important tokenisation takeaway: this is about creating a more efficient, scalable financial infrastructure that can help solve real-world problems, such as housing affordability and access to capital — not speculative trading.

Tokenisation example: home equity and mortgage-related lending — assets divided into smaller, tradeable portions for greater liquidity and access.

Topic 04: Blockchain & Crypto

6. The Role of Banks and Incumbents

Banks don't need to dominate the crypto world

Traditional banks can capture value by becoming strong participants in financial infrastructure: offering API connections, custody solutions, and compliance functions while collaborating with fintech companies, stablecoin issuers, and other players.

Banks' strengths remain essential — but must adapt

Trust, regulatory expertise, and customer access are still valuable. However, banks must adapt to the changing financial landscape. Fintechs must focus on building deeper moats — unique data or ownership of workflow processes — to remain competitive.

Conclusion: The Hybrid Future of Finance

Blockchain and crypto technologies will not fully replace the existing financial system. Instead, they will complement it by tokenising assets and creating programmable money that is faster, cheaper, and more transparent. The future of finance will be a hybrid system where banks, fintechs, and stablecoin issuers collaborate to create seamless, interoperable financial systems. The critical factor: who controls the underlying infrastructure, not just the customer-facing apps.

Topic 05

Intro to InsurTech

Group Reflection

InsurTech is not just about creating new digital insurance brands. The real transformation is happening in the infrastructure that supports insurance — using data, automation, and innovative distribution models to make insurance faster, more efficient, and more personalised.

Topic 05: InsurTech

1. What We Learned About InsurTech and Its Purpose

InsurTech reinvents the insurance product itself

InsurTech is not only about digitising old processes — it's about reinventing the insurance product itself. Instead of static policies renewed once a year, insurance is becoming dynamic and personalised, integrating into real-time data streams to adjust coverage based on actual behaviour, risks, or life events.

The entire value chain is being rebuilt

Technology and data can reshape every step of the insurance value chain — from distribution and underwriting to servicing and claims. This insight fundamentally changed how we understand technology's role in insurance.

Before this topic: we thought insurance was about buying and managing policies from traditional companies. After: we see a dynamic, data-driven system that adjusts to real-world behaviour in real time.

Topic 05: InsurTech

2. Solving Key Problems in Traditional Insurance

Problem 1: Poor customer experience

Traditional insurance is perceived as slow, paper-heavy, and confusing. InsurTech addresses this by providing digital onboarding, easy access, and faster claims processing — using automated data collection, AI, and smart interfaces to significantly reduce friction in selling and claiming insurance.

Problem 2: High operational costs

Legacy systems require manual underwriting, inefficient claims processing, and cumbersome back-office operations. InsurTechs eliminate these inefficiencies through AI, cloud infrastructure, and real-time data — allowing them to operate more efficiently at lower cost.

What InsurTech solves:

- Slow, manual underwriting → AI-powered risk assessment
- Paper-heavy claims processes → digital, automated, photo-based claims
- Lack of personalisation → dynamic, behaviour-based pricing
- High back-office costs → cloud infrastructure and process automation

Topic 05: InsurTech

3. How InsurTech Creates Value in the Insurance Value Chain

Distribution	Digital onboarding, comparison tools, and embedded insurance integrated into other customer journeys (travel, car purchase). Removes friction from buying insurance.
Underwriting & Pricing	Using external data (telematics, wearables, connected devices) to assess risks more accurately and provide granular pricing based on real-time behaviour.
Servicing	Self-service apps, policy changes in-app, and proactive alerts transform how customers interact with insurers — replacing call centres with real-time, digital interaction.
Claims	Photo upload, document automation, and fraud detection systems allow faster, more accurate claims settlement — a critical moment of truth for customer trust.
Risk Prevention	The real shift: from reactive to proactive insurance. Smart-home monitoring, driver feedback, and business risk dashboards help customers prevent losses before they happen.

Topic 05: InsurTech

4. InsurTech Business Models: Not All Are Consumer-Facing

Full-stack digital insurers

Own the customer relationship and take on insurance risk directly.

MGAs and digital distributors

Focus on customer acquisition and product design without becoming a full insurer.

Enablers and infrastructure providers

Provide tools to support underwriting, claims, fraud analytics, and policy administration — like Plaid for insurance.

Embedded insurance players

Integrate insurance into other customer journeys — travel, e-commerce, or mobility. Insurance appears at the point of need.

Key realisation: not every successful InsurTech becomes a consumer brand. Some of the most valuable players are infrastructure providers operating entirely behind the scenes.

Topic 05: InsurTech

5. Key Technologies Behind InsurTech

Data & Analytics

Better data enhances risk assessment, pricing, and fraud detection — enabling more accurate and fair underwriting.

AI & Automation

Machine learning and document extraction speed up decision-making and reduce manual work across the value chain.

APIs & Cloud Infrastructure

Seamless connections between insurers, brokers, platforms, and embedded finance partners — enabling modular, scalable systems.

IoT & Telematics

Cars, homes, and wearables provide real-time data for usage-based and prevention-focused insurance products.

InsurTech is making insurance more continuous — instead of evaluating risk once a year, insurers can continuously update their understanding as new data streams in.

Topic 05: InsurTech

6. Why Insurance Is Harder to Disrupt Than Payments

Structural reasons insurance is difficult to disrupt

Insurance is heavily regulated (rules vary by product and jurisdiction) · Someone must carry the risk capital · Trust is essential for claims payment · Complex back-office systems for claims handling and fraud detection make fast disruption very difficult.

Incumbents are partnering, not being replaced

Instead of being disrupted outright, many traditional insurers are partnering with InsurTechs. This allows incumbents to provide licences, balance sheets, and risk expertise — while InsurTechs improve customer experience and data-driven decision-making.

The future of insurance: better underwriting, faster claims, smarter distribution, more embedded products — built by collaboration between incumbents and InsurTechs.

Topic 05: InsurTech

7. Conclusion: The Future of Insurance

InsurTech is not about innovation for innovation's sake — it's about using technology and data to restructure insurance, making it more personalised, efficient, and proactive.

- InsurTech reinvents the product itself — from static annual policies to dynamic, real-time coverage
- The entire value chain benefits: distribution, underwriting, servicing, claims, and risk prevention
- Not all InsurTechs are consumer-facing — B2B infrastructure providers are often the most valuable
- IoT, AI, and APIs make insurance more continuous, personalised, and predictive
- Insurance is harder to disrupt than payments — incumbents are partnering, not being replaced
- The most successful players will integrate with existing systems and solve real-world problems

Topic 06

Money Without Borders

Group Reflection

Based on the Wise interview and readings on cross-border finance, we came to see that 'money without borders' is not just a slogan about globalisation — it's a focus on creating a seamless, transparent, and trustworthy experience for international payments.

Topic 06: Money Without Borders

1. What We Learned About Cross-Border Finance

The real issue isn't complexity — it's design

We thought international payments were complex due to currencies, regulations, and systems. But the real issue is how fintech can simplify and improve these systems. Wise showed how digital platforms can address complex infrastructure while delivering a transparent, reliable, and intuitive experience.

Rethinking financial needs, not just creating products

Fintech's contribution to cross-border finance is not just about creating new products — it's about rethinking how existing financial needs are addressed. Sending money abroad, paying international suppliers, or managing multiple currencies should feel as simple as domestic payments.

Before this topic: we saw cross-border finance as inherently complex. After: we see it as a design and infrastructure challenge — solvable with the right approach.

Topic 06: Money Without Borders

2. The Importance of User Trust and Simplicity

First-time experience is critical

If onboarding is slow, complicated, or unclear, users may never trust the platform with their money again. In fintech, product design is not just about features — it's about creating a seamless, easy-to-use experience that encourages users to trust the platform from the very first interaction.

Simplicity is a strategic choice

Wise manages enormous complexity in the background — multiple currencies, regulations, and payment rails — while maintaining a clear and simple user journey. This is what sets fintech apart from traditional financial institutions. Simplicity requires fintech companies to balance the technical side with the user-facing experience.

Key principle: hide the complexity, show the simplicity. The infrastructure can be complex — the user experience must not be.

Topic 06: Money Without Borders

3. Solving Real Problems for SMEs and Individuals

SMEs are most impacted by cross-border friction

For small and medium-sized enterprises, cross-border finance affects cash flow, supplier relationships, and international growth. By reducing friction, fintech solutions like Wise can significantly improve operational efficiency and cost-effectiveness for businesses dealing with international payments.

Practical, everyday financial needs — not just crypto

Wise shifts the focus from speculative investment to practical, everyday financial needs. Making it easier for businesses and individuals to make payments, receive money, and manage currencies — with a more dynamic and personalised approach than traditional methods.

SMEs often experience the inefficiencies of traditional banking most acutely — making fintech cross-border solutions especially valuable for this segment.

Topic 06: Money Without Borders

4. The Role of Global Mission and Local Adaptation

Global vision, local execution

The mission of 'money without borders' is global, but the execution needs to be locally adapted. While Wise offers a unified solution, user expectations, local currencies, and payment systems vary significantly by region. Implementation must consider local realities — regulations, consumer behaviour, and market infrastructure.

Not one-size-fits-all — flexible and customisable

The future of cross-border finance isn't about offering a universal solution, but a flexible, customisable product that meets the specific needs of local users while maintaining global connectivity.

Insight: standardisation and localisation must coexist. Global scale requires local relevance.

Topic 06: Money Without Borders

5. Why Cross-Border Finance Is Strategically Relevant in Fintech

User trust is critical	Fintech companies create value by building trust — predictable pricing, clear communication, and transparent processes.
Infrastructure matters	Success depends on connections to local payment rails, compliance processes, and operational reliability. Must scale globally while staying locally flexible.
SME relevance	Cross-border payments impact small businesses more directly than large corporations — making this segment highly strategic for fintechs.
Competitive landscape	Banks, remittance firms, and fintechs all compete here. The winner combines regulatory credibility with a seamless customer journey.
Scalability challenge	International scaling requires balancing standardisation with regional customisation — a complex operational and product challenge.

Topic 06: Money Without Borders

6. The Biggest Takeaway

'Money without borders' is not just about a globalised financial system — it's about rethinking financial infrastructure to make international money movement feel as simple, transparent, and trustworthy as local payments.

- Cross-border complexity is a design and infrastructure challenge — not an insurmountable barrier
- First-time user experience is critical: onboarding determines long-term trust
- Simplicity for the user must hide enormous complexity underneath
- SMEs are the most impacted by cross-border friction — and the most valuable target segment
- Global mission + local adaptation = the Wise formula for scale
- The fintech that wins will make cross-border feel like local — through infrastructure, trust, and UX

Topic 07

Open & Beyond Banking

Group Reflection

We began thinking open banking was just a regulatory requirement. We now see it as a strategic opportunity for banks to transform their role — from isolated financial service providers to integral parts of the customer journey.

Topic 07: Open & Beyond Banking

1. What We Learned About Open Banking and Its Strategic Importance

Beyond compliance: creating new business models

We initially understood open banking as a regulatory requirement (PSD2). We now see it as a strategic opportunity to create new business models and expand financial ecosystems. Banks can use APIs to embed their services into customers' daily lives, creating more value and relevance.

Banks as integral parts of the customer journey

Open banking allows banks to move from being isolated institutions providing standalone products to connecting seamlessly with third-party platforms and services. Banks can now embed tailored financial solutions directly into customers' journeys — e-commerce, fintechs, or third-party platforms.

Key mindset shift for our group:

Traditional view: banks as isolated institutions providing standalone products.

New view: banks as infrastructure providers embedded in broader customer journeys — more relevant, more integrated, more valuable.

Topic 07: Open & Beyond Banking

2. Moving Beyond Compliance: The Role of APIs and Embedded Finance

From compliance to revenue generation

Many banks initially treat open banking as a compliance burden — ticking boxes without a clear strategy. The real opportunity lies in repositioning banks as infrastructure providers through premium APIs, real-time data, and partner ecosystems.

Embedding financial services into non-financial platforms

Open banking allows banks to embed services into accounting software, ERP systems, and digital platforms used daily. This is where beyond banking becomes real: solving broader customer needs — in housing, customers may need mortgages, but also insurance, valuations, and relocation support.

Key insight: beyond banking is not about random lifestyle features. It's about solving larger, integrated customer needs by embedding finance where it matters most.

Topic 07: Open & Beyond Banking

3. The Business-Model Ladder: From Open Banking to Beyond Banking

1	**Open Banking**	Opening up data and payment functions through APIs.
2	**Platform Banking**	Banks offer platforms where partners can add services or products.
3	**Embedded Banking/Finance**	Financial services integrated into non-financial journeys — lending in e-commerce, BNPL.
4	**Ecosystems**	Banks work with partners around broader value propositions: housing, mobility, healthcare, SME management.
5	**Beyond Banking**	The bank becomes a platform helping solve life or business needs — not just providing traditional banking services.

The further up the ladder, the more integrated and valuable — but also the more complex to execute.

Topic 07: Open & Beyond Banking

4. Why Banks Are Interested in Beyond Banking

Better customer value

By solving a broader set of problems, banks become more relevant and indispensable to customers.

More loyalty and engagement

Being present in daily customer journeys makes it harder for customers to switch banks.

New acquisition routes

Offering non-financial services can bring in new users who might not otherwise seek out a bank.

New revenue streams

Partner commissions, distribution fees, and premium APIs offer new ways to generate income.

Data advantage

Transaction data and contextual information enable more personalised and timely services.

Rebundling

Fintech has unbundled banking. Beyond banking represents a shift back toward bundling — creating fuller, more integrated solutions.

Topic 07: Open & Beyond Banking

5. Why Execution Is Difficult

Barriers to beyond banking implementation

Despite clear opportunities, executing the beyond banking vision is challenging. Legacy technology, lack of connectivity, and too much reliance on in-house development are major barriers. Many banks understand the importance of open banking but struggle with the technical and cultural challenges of implementing it.

Not every bank should try to own the entire ecosystem

Some banks may be better off by participating in existing ecosystems and learning the economics before trying to orchestrate their own. Banks need to partner with retailers, telecoms, and software providers — rather than trying to do everything themselves.

Key lesson: partnerships and collaboration are just as important as internal innovation in beyond banking.

Topic 07: Open & Beyond Banking

6. Super Apps and the 'Beyond Banking' Debate

The super app concept — WeChat as a model

A super app is a one-stop platform where users can do everything from ordering food to paying bills to accessing banking services. The WeChat example from China is compelling — but replicating it in Western markets is much harder due to fragmented consumer habits, competition from existing platforms, and privacy concerns.

The real lesson: low-friction, integrated user journeys

The key takeaway is not about replicating WeChat, but about creating low-friction, integrated user journeys. Banks can offer modular ecosystems, partnered services, and selective all-in-one experiences without necessarily becoming a universal super app.

KBC as a concrete example:

KBC moved from digital channels to integrating non-financial services (public transport tickets, partner deals) into its mobile app. Rather than abandoning its core business, KBC leveraged beyond banking to strengthen its position as a trusted advisor. AI-powered Kate, KBC's digital assistant, exemplifies how data-driven services can transform customer relationships.

Topic 07: Open & Beyond Banking

7 & 8. KBC Case + Conclusion: The Future of Open and Beyond Banking

Open banking and beyond banking are fundamentally about reorganising financial services around data, APIs, and customer-centric ecosystems. The future lies not in controlling everything, but in becoming a trusted part of broader customer journeys.

- Open banking is a strategic opportunity — not just a compliance burden
- The business-model ladder: Open Banking → Platform → Embedded Finance → Ecosystems → Beyond Banking
- Beyond banking solves broader customer needs, not just financial ones
- Benefits: customer loyalty, new revenue streams, data advantage, and rebundling
- Execution is hard: legacy tech, cultural barriers, and ecosystem complexity must be managed
- Partnerships are essential — no bank can or should build everything in-house
- KBC shows how a traditional bank can transition to beyond banking without abandoning its core

Topic 08

Payments

Group Reflection

We began thinking of payments as back-office plumbing. We now understand that payments are a strategic driver — determining who controls the user interface, who collects data, and who earns fees in the financial ecosystem.

Topic 08: Payments

1. What We Learned About the Role of Payments in Fintech

Payments = ecosystems, not just transactions

Fintech companies are not just offering a payment button or a card — they are building ecosystems around acceptance, fraud detection, identity, treasury services, and cross-border settlement. The real value of payments lies in speed, trust, platform power, and access to real-time financial data.

Embedding payments into broader journeys

Payments have evolved from a growth engine to essential financial infrastructure. Fintechs are embedding payments into the broader customer journey — e-commerce, mobile wallets, banking apps — to simplify and transform the user experience in ways that were not possible before.

Shift in thinking: payments are not just functional — they are strategic. Who controls the payment experience often gains the most power in the financial ecosystem.

Topic 08: Payments

2. Key Themes from the Capco Report

AI-driven payments

AI is integral to the payments ecosystem — used for fraud detection, anomaly monitoring, and smarter real-time decisions. This allows payments to be processed faster and more securely.

Instant payments

Speed is now an expected standard, not a premium feature. The adoption of instant payments across Europe means consumers and businesses expect to send and receive money immediately, 24/7.

APIs in payments

APIs allow different platforms, merchants, and banks to connect their payment functions into a single digital journey. This reduces friction and makes the entire payment process faster and more transparent.

Digital currencies (CBDCs)

Central bank digital currencies are becoming a potential alternative to traditional money. They offer significant implications for cross-border payments — cheaper, faster, and more transparent settlement options.

Topic 08: Payments

3. The Strategic Importance of Payments in Fintech

Payments as a strategic lever for growth

Payments are not just a technical service — they have become a strategic lever for growth and customer engagement. The most successful fintech companies create a seamless, integrated payment experience, embedding payments into broader digital journeys.

Payments in accounting, ERP, and platform ecosystems

Embedding payment solutions into accounting software, ERP systems, and digital platforms allows for a much smoother experience than traditional methods. Whoever controls the payment experience often gains control over the customer relationship and data.

Core lesson: payments are now central to the customer experience — companies that embed payments into broader digital journeys will have the competitive upper hand.

Topic 08: Payments

4. Key Insights from the Three Videos

Apple vs. Banks — The Digital-Wallet War

Payments are a battle for the customer interface. While banks provide accounts and compliance, digital wallets like Apple Pay or Google Pay can own the customer-facing experience. If wallet providers dominate, banks risk becoming commoditised utilities, losing control over customer data and transaction insights.

India's Digital Payment Boom

India's UPI system demonstrated how instant payments can become mass-market solutions, overcoming inefficiencies in the traditional banking system. Payments innovation doesn't always come from the West — emerging markets like India can be testbeds for models that scale quickly and efficiently.

BRICS, SWIFT Alternatives & Payment Geopolitics

Payments systems are not just about consumer technology — they are deeply embedded in global trade, sanctions, and national sovereignty. The rise of BRICS alternative systems signals that payment rails are a political issue as much as a technical one. Who controls payment rails has broader implications for global economic power.

Topic 08: Payments

5 & 6. The Future of Payments & Conclusion

Payments are no longer just a functional service — they are a strategic layer in fintech, determining how financial services are delivered, who owns the customer relationship, and who controls the data.

- The future of payments lies in interoperability between different payment systems, currencies, and technologies
- Instant payments, APIs, and digital currencies will make cross-border payments cheaper, faster, and more transparent
- The payments landscape will be modular — different players competing to control different parts of the infrastructure
- Ownership of the front-end experience is now a crucial competitive factor — banks risk losing this to wallets
- Emerging markets (India's UPI) are proving that innovative payment models can scale fast
- Payments are geopolitical — SWIFT alternatives and CBDCs reflect the broader battle for financial sovereignty
- Winners master speed, trust, and user experience — while controlling critical infrastructure layers

Topic 09

FinTech Landscape

Group Reflection

Fintech has matured into an industry focused on scale, economics, regulation, AI, and onchain finance. Our perspective shifted from seeing fintech as a disruptive force to understanding it as a builder of durable, profitable models that solve real-world problems.

Topic 09: FinTech Landscape

1. What We Learned About the Fintech Landscape Today

From disruption to durable ecosystems

We initially viewed fintech as a series of consumer apps disrupting traditional banking. The materials made it clear that fintech's real value today lies in creating sustainable growth and building reliable infrastructures that serve both consumers and businesses.

The biggest story: from unbundling to scalable ecosystems

Companies that have succeeded moved beyond simple products to build holistic systems embedded within broader financial ecosystems. The future of fintech will be shaped by AI, onchain finance, challenger bank evolution, and B2B infrastructure opportunities.

Key takeaway: fintech is no longer about disrupting old systems — it's about creating value in scalable, profitable, and integrated ways. AI and onchain finance are central to this evolution.

Topic 09: FinTech Landscape

2. Fintech Growth and Maturity

21%

Fintech revenue growth in 2024

~3x faster than traditional financial services

69%

of public fintechs turned a profit in 2024

A sign of operational maturity across the sector

What this means

We initially thought of fintech as a disruptive force that would dominate traditional financial institutions. We now realise the key to success is sustainable growth, not just rapid expansion. The strongest players have improved profitability while focusing on scalability and customer value.

Topic 09: FinTech Landscape

3. The Business-Model Ladder: Open Banking to Beyond Banking

1	**Open Banking**	Banks open data and payment functionality through APIs, enabling third parties to access financial data and initiate payments with customer consent.
2	**Platform Banking**	Banks provide infrastructure, distribution, and platform for partners to add products and services on top.
3	**Embedded Finance**	Financial services (payments, lending, insurance) integrated into non-financial customer journeys — e-commerce checkout, travel bookings.
4	**Ecosystems**	Banks collaborate with other service providers to create comprehensive ecosystems extending beyond traditional banking products.
5	**Beyond Banking**	The final stage: offering services that go beyond traditional banking, addressing life or business needs — health, housing, education, mobility.

Beyond banking is not about random lifestyle features — it's about creating value through integrated financial services that solve broader customer needs.

Topic 09: FinTech Landscape

4. Why Open Banking Matters Beyond Compliance

From regulatory requirement to strategic opportunity

Open banking is no longer just about PSD2 compliance. Banks can now partner with fintechs and third-party service providers to embed financial services into platforms like e-commerce, marketplaces, or digital tools.

New revenue streams through APIs, data, and partner ecosystems

The real opportunity is in creating new revenue streams through APIs, real-time data, and partner ecosystems. By embedding finance directly into existing workflows, banks become part of the customer journey rather than offering isolated banking products.

Critical insight: open banking allows banks to move from transaction providers to ecosystem participants — staying relevant even as other brands own the customer-facing experience.

Topic 09: FinTech Landscape

5. The Role of AI and Agentic Commerce in the Future of Fintech

Agentic AI — the next evolution

We initially thought of AI in fintech as something used for fraud detection or customer service. We now understand that agentic AI — AI that can monitor, decide, and act with limited prompting — could become a core part of fintech's future, driving efficiency, personalisation, and autonomy across payments, lending, and savings optimisation.

AI as autonomous decision-making infrastructure

AI is not just an add-on — it will eventually power autonomous decision-making systems that enhance fintech products across the value chain. This shift towards agentic AI signals the next step in fintech evolution: smarter, more efficient, and more personalised.

The progression: AI as a tool → AI as a copilot → AI as an autonomous agent operating within defined policy guardrails.

Topic 09: FinTech Landscape

6. Challenges and Barriers to Execution

The execution gap

Legacy systems, lack of connectivity, and weak ecosystems are barriers that many fintechs and banks still face. It's not enough to have great products — successful fintech companies need a robust tech stack, data quality, strong compliance, and an effective partner network.

Partnerships over in-house control

Not all banks should try to own the entire ecosystem. It may be more strategic to join existing ecosystems and learn from them rather than building everything in-house. This reshaped our thinking: partnerships and collaboration are as important as innovation.

Key realisation: the companies that win in fintech are not always those with the best technology — they are those with the best partnerships, ecosystems, and execution discipline.

Topic 09: FinTech Landscape

7. Conclusion: The Future of Fintech

Fintech's future is no longer about disrupting banks or building cool apps. It's about building better financial ecosystems, empowering customers, and creating value through data, technology, and partnerships.

- Fintech revenues grew 21% in 2024 — 3x faster than traditional financial services
- 69% of public fintechs are now profitable — the industry has matured beyond the hype
- The business-model ladder: Open Banking → Platform → Embedded Finance → Ecosystems → Beyond Banking
- Agentic AI will power autonomous decision-making across payments, lending, and savings
- Partnerships and collaboration are as important as internal innovation
- The most successful fintechs combine: scalability + economic discipline + regulatory compliance + trust
- AI, onchain finance, and embedded finance will define the next wave of fintech innovation

Our Conclusion on Fintech

Group 2 – Fintech Bootcamp

Fintech, to us, is the art of making complex financial systems invisible to the people who need them most — embedding trust, speed, and intelligence into the infrastructure of everyday life, so that money moves as freely and fairly as information does in the digital age.

9 topics · 1 journey · one clear insight: fintech is not about disruption — it's about building a better financial system for everyone.